LEGENDS OF RAJASTHAN

In October 1567 a large Mughal force arrived in Mewar during a thunderstorm so furious that, as the imperial tents were pitched, the rain scuffed the countryside around them into watery shadows. The next morning, however, the clouds dispersed and rising from the rainswept plains the troops saw a fortress made by giants, nearly 5 kilometres long and rising from a hill, a ship of stone in an endless sea. This was Chittor, capital of Mewar, and scene of extravagant acts of gallantry in past centuries by both men and women. It was also, more prosaically, on the trade route from Delhi to Gwalior, and a worthy adversary for Akbar in the battle for Rajasthan. All the palaces, havelis and bazaars of Chittor were within its fortifications and high on the hill were two great towers, the Jai Kirti Stambh (Pillar of Fame) and the Jai Stambh (Pillar of Victory), eloquent symbols of a past glory. Enormous stone reservoirs were filled with rainwater and Udai Singh, Rana of Chittor, ‘knew his own strength and felt at ease about Chittor because the Emperor’s force had but little siege apparatus and it did not seem likely that he would attempt to reduce the place’. So sanguine did Udai Singh feel about the safety of Chittor that he left it in the care of the Rathore chief Jaimal ‘Mertia’ of Badnor while he and his entire court removed themselves to their other capital at Udaipur.

Though historian James Tod, a great proponent of the history of Rajasthan, would bitterly criticize Udai Singh for his failure to exhibit the exemplary Rajput bravery expected of him when he wrote scathingly that ‘the absence of the kingly virtues in the sovereign of Mewar filled to the brim the bitter cup of her destiny’, the rana was not altogether deluded in placing his faith in Chittor’s natural defences. The fortresses of Hindustan were formidable structures, constructed with great quantities of stone and rising to imposing heights. Built on a substantial hill, Chittor was the largest fort at the time, its stone walls bristling with watch towers and iron-spiked doors. The fortress was well stocked with supplies, ammunition, water, and a garrison of 8,000 warriors. The garrison, it is said, ‘uttered cries of derision’, when they saw the paltry force that had had the audacity to besiege their mighty fortress. The Rajputs hunkered down to watch what